

TWENTY THOUSAND LEAGUES UNDER THE SEA

A Voyage of Discovery Beneath the Waves

JULES VERNE

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Chapter One — The Shape in the Deep

For months the shipping lanes had carried whispers of a shape moving beneath the waves, faster than any vessel afloat and indifferent to cannon fire. Captains logged it as a reef that should not exist; naturalists argued for a creature no book had catalogued.

It was Professor Pierre Arnaux who first suggested, quietly and then loudly, that the thing beneath the swells was neither reef nor beast but a vessel of impossible design, and that whoever built it did not wish to be found.

When the frigate Alcyon finally closed on the shape one moonless night, the sea itself seemed to hold its breath before the water split open in a curtain of phosphorescent spray.

Chapter Two — Into the Iron Hull

The corridor beyond the airlock hummed with a low, contented sound, as though the ship itself were breathing. Brass fittings gleamed under lamps that needed no flame, and the floor was carpeted in charts of oceans no living cartographer had drawn.

Their host received them in a library ringed with portholes of curved glass, through which the deep sea slid past like a slow, endless curtain of ink and starlight.

"You will want to know where we are going," he said, before any question could be asked. "The truthful answer is: wherever the current of my own curiosity carries us next."